

The CASCA Statement of Ethics/Code of Conduct

Adopted: December 15, 2025

Acknowledgements: The contents of these documents were created with inspiration from the [AAS Code of Ethics](#), the [IAU Code of Conduct](#), the [LSST DESC Code of Conduct](#), and the [Simons Foundation Code of Conduct](#).

We also note that this Code of Conduct is intended to exist in addition to any specific codes of conduct related to meetings such as an AGM. In the event of a conflict between this Code of Conduct and any meeting-specific document, this Code of Conduct shall prevail.

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Purpose and application

The Canadian Astronomical Society - Société canadienne d'astronomie ("CASCA" or "Society") seeks to promote and advance knowledge of the universe through research and education. CASCA serves as a national forum for scientific planning and astronomy.

CASCA members are expected to uphold high standards of ethical behaviour and integrity in scientific research, and must always treat others fairly, respectfully and equitably. CASCA members recognize and affirm that academic and research activities take place on lands that have been home to Indigenous peoples. CASCA members acknowledge their broader responsibilities to diverse communities and are expected to uphold values of inclusivity.

This Statement of Ethics / Code of Conduct ("Code of Conduct") outlines the fundamental values and principles which establish a common set of expectations and standards of conduct for CASCA members as they carry on astronomy study, research, teaching and supervision of students. Changes to this Code of Conduct may be made periodically by the CASCA Equity and Inclusion Committee in consultation with the CASCA board and other relevant groups.

CASCA is one stakeholder in a broader astronomical community, which includes universities and colleges, research institutions, professional associations, companies, not-for-profit organizations, and individuals. Each stakeholder contributes to upholding scientific, educational and ethical standards, and the enforcement of such standards. Accordingly, CASCA may not always be the primary or appropriate jurisdiction for investigating or adjudicating certain complaints and breaches.

CASCA members are expected to always abide by this Code of Conduct, and prospective members must agree to the terms of the Code of Conduct as a condition of acceptance into the Society. Not agreeing to the Code of Conduct will be equivalent to not paying dues to the Society and will result in a loss of good standing. CASCA members must read and familiarize themselves with this Code of Conduct, including any changes made from time to time.

Interpersonal behaviours

Guiding Principles

Recognizing the inherent worth of all people and treating all others with respect is fundamental to enable the field of astronomy to advance scientifically and to remain relevant in the wider world.

Conduct Toward Others

CASCA members should strive to create and support an environment that encourages the free expression and exchange of scientific ideas via all modes of communication (e.g., in-person, online, and written formats). Scientists should treat their colleagues equitably and fairly regardless of their characteristics including, but not limited to (given in alphabetical order): age, career path, career stage, CASCA membership status, choice of language, colour, conviction for an offence for which a pardon has been granted or in respect of which a record suspension has been ordered, disability, ethnicity, family status, field of study, gender, gender expression, gender identity, genetic characteristics, Indigeneity, lactation, marital status, nationality, physical appearance, political affiliation, pregnancy, race, religion, research institution affiliation, sexual orientation, status as a caregiver (including as a parent).¹

CASCA will not tolerate behaviour that is discriminatory, abusive, demeaning, humiliating, or intimidating. Members of our community who are senior in their career stage should recognize their responsibility to support the development of their trainees in research skills, providing education and supporting the professional development of their trainees. This includes providing a work environment that is safe, supportive, and free from discrimination, bullying and harassment, to the extent possible within their sphere of influence and responsibility. Supervisors should also provide reasonable and fair compensation and feedback, acknowledge the work and contribution of their trainees to any research results, and respect them as individuals. Supervisors should protect the academic freedom of their trainees to disagree with or dispute wider community-held scientific positions without fear of retaliation. Supervisors should encourage their graduate students to graduate in a timely manner and support them in their career goals, whether inside or outside of an academic track.²

¹ <https://laws-lois.justice.gc.ca/eng/acts/h-6/page-1.html#h-256800>

² <https://aas.org/policies/ethics>

The following sections provide details regarding specific examples of unacceptable behaviours: discrimination, harassment, sexual harassment, and bullying.

Discrimination

CASCA is committed to fostering an inclusive, respectful, and equitable environment for all individuals that is free from discrimination of all kinds. Racism, xenophobia, and any form of discrimination based on ethnicity, race, national origin, language, or cultural background are unacceptable and will not be tolerated. Members are expected to actively contribute to an environment where individuals of all backgrounds feel respected, safe, and valued. Examples of unacceptable discriminatory behaviour include stereotyping, making inappropriate jokes based on a person's cultural background, and discussing a person's fitness for employment being linked to their race or ethnicity.

Harassment

CASCA does not tolerate harassment of any kind, including but not limited to verbal harassment, non-verbal harassment, psychological harassment or physical harassment. Behaviours and language acceptable to one person may not be to another. Members must make every effort to ensure that words and actions communicate respect for others. In general, harassment is engaging in a course of conduct (or one single egregious act) that exerts unwelcome pressure, discomfort, insecurity, offence, humiliation or intimidation.

Such conduct includes, but is not limited to: epithets, slurs or stereotyping; threatening, intimidating or hostile acts; denigrating jokes and display or circulation of written or graphic material that denigrates or shows hostility or aversion towards an individual or group; unwelcome, unwanted physical contact (e.g., physical assault or violating an individual's personal space).

Sexual Harassment

The Canada Labour Code defines sexual harassment as "any conduct, comment, gesture, or contact of a sexual nature that is likely to cause offence or humiliation to any employee; or that might, on reasonable grounds, be perceived by that employee as placing a condition of a sexual nature on employment or on any opportunity for training or promotion".³ Sexual harassment may include unwelcome sexual attention, sexual solicitation or advances, stalking, harassing, photographing or recording, inappropriate physical contact.² Sexual harassment may also include engaging in a course of vexatious comment or conduct because of sex, sexual orientation, gender identity or gender expression, where the course of comment or conduct is known or ought to reasonably be known to be unwelcome.

Sexual harassment can often appear in at least two different types²:

³ <https://www.justice.gc.ca/eng/fund-fina/harassment-harcelement.html>

- “Quid pro quo” harassment. This is where there is a real or perceived threat that decisions related to hiring (such as writing letters of reference), promotions or decisions related to preferential treatment are connected to the submission (or refusal to submit) to unwelcome sexual attention, requests or demands for sexual favours, verbal comments or physical conduct of a sexual nature.
- Harassment related to a “hostile work environment.” Here, the harassment creates an offensive, hostile or unpleasant working environment and unreasonably interferes with an individual’s job performance. This form of harassment often includes persistent or pervasive conduct (or from one single egregious act) or comments within the workplace that are sexually oriented with the purpose or effect of creating an intimidating, hostile, or offensive work environment.

Sexually oriented conduct can include, but is not limited to, innuendoes, suggestive comments, jokes of a sexual nature, sexual propositions, lewd remarks or other forms of verbal sexual harassment. Sexually oriented conduct can also include nonverbal sexual harassment, such as displaying, sharing/distributing or discussing sexually oriented written or graphic material or unwelcome, unwanted, unrequested, or uninvited physical contact of a sexual nature.

Bullying

The AAS Code of Ethics defines bullying as “unwelcome or unreasonable behaviour that demeans, intimidates, humiliates, or sabotages the work of people, either as individuals or as a group.”³ Behaviour characterized as bullying may occur repeatedly over time or in a single significantly harmful act of intimidation. It can be enacted by an individual or through group actions. Individuals who bully may also involve others who, knowingly or unknowingly, support or enable the behavior.

While exercising appropriate authority, training and directing the work of others in their roles and engaging in scientific debate and dialogue are not considered bullying behaviour, repeated slandering, ridiculing, or maligning a person and their scientific contribution, making abusive, personal or offensive remarks about a person or their work are examples of verbal bullying. Physical bullying includes pushing, poking, assaulting, threatening assault, or damaging a person’s work area or property, while gesture bullying involves generating nonverbal threatening gestures.^{2,3} Finally, sabotaging an individual’s work or the ability to produce science (e.g., repeatedly refusing to grant telescope resources due to an undisclosed conflict of interest) is considered bullying.

Scientific behaviours

Guiding Principles

Research ethics are central to the practice of science, and underpin our connection as scientists within Canada and in the international arena⁴. This section contains the core principles and guidelines emphasizing ethical conduct, responsibility, integrity, and

⁴<https://science.gc.ca/site/science/en/office-chief-science-advisor/scientific-integrity/model-policy-scientific-integrity>

professionalism across various facets of scientific work, including research, publication, peer review, conflict of interest management, and professional behaviour in physics, astronomy and engineering. It underscores the commitment to maintaining high ethical standards in the scientific community.

Conduct in Research and Publication

The CASCA Code of Conduct:

- Prohibits research misconduct, including plagiarism and data fabrication.
- Stresses the timely dissemination of results and correcting misleading errors.
- Emphasizes the need for original work, appropriate authorship, error correction, acknowledgment of contributions, proper citation, and the avoidance of plagiarism and self-plagiarism in all scientific communications.
- Expects members to recognize, manage and disclose conflicts of interest.

Peer Review and Conflicts of Interest

Research relies on fair, objective, and confidential peer review. CASCA members should recognize and manage potential conflicts of interest in scientific endeavours and disclose these conflicts of interest following appropriate guidelines. For Canadian researchers, these include the [NSERC guidelines](#) and the [Model for Scientific Integrity](#) developed by the Office of the Chief Science Advisor of Canada, as they pertain to astronomical research.

The Code of Conduct prohibits violations of ethical standards of peer review and conflict of interest (e.g., a member of the Scientific Organizing Committee of a CASCA AGM abusing their power to keep someone from giving a talk at the CASCA AGM due to a conflict of interest). CASCA members must be aware of the possibilities for conflicts of interest, disclose conflicts of interest and recuse themselves as appropriate.

Research Assessments

Research assessments are an integral part of furthering astronomical research. Research assessments include but are not limited to evaluating the quality and impact of research output in the context of a nomination for a research prize, reviewing applications for graduate programs and filling an employment position in the astronomical research community.

CASCA members should recognize and manage potential conflicts of interest in scientific endeavours, disclose these conflicts of interest following appropriate guidelines, and take precautionary measures to avoid conflicts wherever possible.

Scientific Integrity and Misconduct

CASCA members should model honest and ethical conduct in research. The open exchange of ideas and ethical debate following principles of respect is central to scientific progress.⁵

⁵ <https://www.simonsfoundation.org/code-of-conduct>

As such, the Code of Conduct prohibits falsification, plagiarism, failing to give proper credit for other people's work, and other forms of scientific misconduct in all forms of scientific communications, including but not limited to scholarly journals, proposals, talks (e.g., at a CASCA AGM), books and podcasts.

Professional Conduct in Astronomy and Astrophysics

The practice of astronomy and astrophysics should proceed with integrity, competence, and diligence. Members should take care in maintaining and advancing professional knowledge, providing honest feedback to others, and making clear the consequences of violating principles of research ethics. CASCA members have a responsibility to report unethical practices in the astronomy community to relevant bodies, including their respective institutions and CASCA.

Implementation of the Code of Conduct

Violations of the Code of Conduct will be addressed following the Code of Conduct Implementation Policy approved by the CASCA Board and posted on the CASCA website.

CASCA members are granted membership privileges as set out in the by-laws; however, such privileges may be revoked by the CASCA Board in accordance with the by-laws, including but not limited to violations of this Code of Conduct.

While complaints about conduct towards others and scientific behaviours might appropriately be reported to other institutions that are a part of the astronomical community first, behaviours that violate the CASCA Code of Conduct can be reported as part of the CASCA process in addition to any institutional reporting.

Retaliation against those who have made Code of Conduct complaints in good faith or against those who have participated or co-operated in any investigation related to a Code of Conduct complaint is considered to be a violation of the Code of Conduct.

Proposed Implementation Plan

CASCA Ombudspersons

CASCA members may contact one of the CASCA ombudspersons for confidential consultation and discussion in advance (or instead) of any formal complaint. These discussions may form the majority of the cases where potential violations of the Code of Conduct may have occurred and will amount to the main avenue for informal resolution of more minor Code of Conduct violations.

The CASCA ombudspersons will be two members of the CASCA community who do not have leadership positions within CASCA and serve on no CASCA committees during their term as ombudspersons (the appointments of the ombudspeople will be staggered to keep annual costs to CASCA evenly distributed). The CASCA ombudspersons will be appointed

by the CASCA Board, and are not elected. The term for CASCA ombudspersons is three years. The CASCA ombudspersons can serve for up to two consecutive terms. The ombudspersons will undergo training from and maintain membership in the International Ombuds Association⁶ or the Forum of Canadian Ombudsman⁷. The costs of this plan are described in Addendum A.

The primary duties of the CASCA ombudspersons are to work with individuals and groups in CASCA to explore and assist them in determining options to help resolve conflicts, problematic issues or concerns related to the Code of Conduct. As such the role of the ombudsperson is to listen and understand the issues while remaining neutral. The ombudsperson listens to understand the issue from the perspective of the individual and may reframe an issue to help individuals evaluate the options before them (including having a mediated discussion with another party, reporting an issue to their institution, and lodging a formal complaint of a Code of Conduct violation to CASCA).

The CASCA ombudsperson operates in a manner to preserve the confidentiality of those seeking services, maintains a neutral/impartial position with respect to the concerns raised and does not represent CASCA. If one ombudsperson has a conflict of interest with any party involved, the other CASCA ombudsperson can undertake their duties. If both ombudspersons have a conflict of interest with any party involved, legal counsel will be retained.

A formal complaint of a violation of the CASCA Code of Conduct

Someone with a concern about a CASCA member violating the Code of Conduct for CASCA-related work may make a formal complaint to the CASCA President, who will then appoint a *primary contact for handling the implementation of the Code of Conduct*. If the complaint is made against or involves anyone on the CASCA Board (including the President), an independent committee will be formed from members of legal counsel, who will manage the complaint process. Where appropriate, informal resolution will be encouraged at all stages of the formal complaint process.

In the case of a formal complaint made against CASCA members who are not on the Board, the primary contact will designate an independent 3-person committee of CASCA members. The chair of the committee will become the primary contact for the complaint. The committee is tasked to consider submissions from the complainant(s) and the respondent(s) who shall receive a copy of the formal complaint, interview witnesses if appropriate, determine whether there was a breach of the Code of Conduct, and make recommendations for any resulting actions. The committee's work will culminate in an investigation report. The committee will have access to resources, such as legal counsel or external investigators, if needed. Individuals to whom complaints are reported, who were witnesses to the alleged behaviour, who are consulted during the grievance process or who otherwise have a conflict of interest should disclose such conflicts of interest and recuse themselves from managing or investigating complaints. The CASCA Board may consider standing up a larger group of CASCA members who are willing in advance to serve on these 3-person committees.

⁶ <https://www.ombudsassociation.org/>

⁷ https://www.ombudsmanforum.ca/osgoode_fco_certificate_-_esse.php

The investigation report will include, firstly, *whether* a breach of the Code of Conduct has been established and, if there was a breach, recommended sanctions. These sanctions can include, but are not limited to:

- Training;
- Mentorship;
- Mediated conversations/dialogue between parties involved;
- Removal or suspension from leadership or other positions within CASCA; and
- Revoking CASCA membership and denying participation in CASCA meetings.

The complainant(s) and the respondent(s) shall be entitled to receive a copy of the investigation report and have the opportunity to make written submissions regarding the investigation report for consideration by the CASCA Board.

The chair of the committee will become the primary contact for the complaint and will present the investigation report to the CASCA Board and will be available to answer questions. The CASCA Board will directly communicate the outcome of the investigation to the complainant(s) and the respondent(s).

The CASCA Board will determine whether they agree that a breach of the Code of Conduct has been established, and if so, they will determine which of the sanctions (some of which are listed above) recommended by the committee to impose. They may impose additional sanctions if needed. Failure of the CASCA member to comply with the imposed sanctions may lead to an escalation of sanctions by the Board.

The CASCA Board will vote on the matter by secret ballot, which will be administered by the chair of the committee. The matter will require the majority of CASCA Board members to agree on whether there was a breach of the Code of Conduct, and if so, the sanctions.

In addition, pursuant to the by-laws, the CASCA Board has the authority to expel any CASCA member from CASCA on the grounds of receiving a censure or sanction from a university, research institution, professional association or professional research collaboration within the astronomical community for an activity that constitutes a violation of the CASCA Code of Conduct. The process set out in the by-laws would apply in such cases.

Addendum A: Costs of the Code of Conduct Implementation

The cost (as of May 2025) of implementing the Code of Conduct are:

- Annual International Ombuds Association (IOA) membership: USD 300/person/year, plus USD 1895 initial training per person. **USD 4390 for first year, USD 600 for subsequent years**; or
- Essentials for Ombuds training plan from Forum of Canadian Ombudsman: CAD 125/person/year, plus CAD 3695+tax per training per person. **CAD 7640 for first year, CAD 250 for subsequent years.** *5-day in-person training*